how this had happened, Prime Minister Modi and his advisors chose to do something even more daring than the surgical strikes across the LoC. India's armed forces had orders to hit back 'at a place and time of their choice', and they did precisely that. In the most audacious air strikes since the 1971 Indo-Pak War, the Indian Air Force bombed a major terrorist camp in Balakot, in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. During the Kargil conflict in 1999, Prime Minister Vajpayee had insisted that India's military responses should be limited to the Indian side of the LoC. Most importantly, it showed that India wasn't going to be held hostage to Pakistan's decades-old strategy to keep using terrorism to push its anti-India foreign policy, under the umbrella of its nuclear weapons, assuming that India would bear the repeated attacks in silence.[12] Once again, Pakistan's establishment was first shocked, until it carried out, a day later, an air intrusion across the LoC, dropping bombs at Indian military installations that fortunately missed their targets. India's swift response to the Pakistani air intrusion led to a dog fight between a vintage MiG-21 and Pakistan's F-16s, in which a MiG-21 took down the F-16. Later, the MiG was shot down by a Pakistani air-to-air missile. But Pakistan's Inter-Services Public Relations, and its state-controlled media, continues to deny that one of their F-16s was shot down.

Even though China wants Pakistan's military to keep India on the back foot, is a party to the Kashmir dispute and has strategic interests in the region with projects in POK, it is also now giving Pakistan all the support that it desperately needs to extricate itself from the corner it has dug itself into, as the epicentre of terrorism in the region. India's responses have pushed Pakistan's deep state into an abyss. Clearly, Pakistan's three-decade-long *jihad* may now have run its course. But without India willing to confront China on its support for Pakistan, New Delhi's efforts to get the world to isolate Pakistan further would bear little fruit.

The realisation should dawn on India's strategists that Pakistan and China are very close, like the lips and teeth epithet originally coined by Mao in relation to North Korea. Today, Pakistan has replaced North Korea in terms of its importance to the Middle Kingdom.[13] The last chapter will